

Questions fly over Putnam UFO

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What's triangular, big as a football field, has red, white and green lights, and swoops over the tree tops at night?

Nobody knows exactly what it is, but researchers are looking into several hundred reported sightings of an unidentified flying object in Putnam and Westchester counties over the past several weeks.

"As far as I'm concerned, we have a great mystery here," said Philip Imbrogno, a high school science teacher from Greenwich who is gathering information on the sightings for the Center for UFO Studies in Evanston, Ill.

Imbrogno and a team of five researchers began studying the sightings a week and a half ago after reading newspaper accounts of the phenomenon.

The first of the most recent series of reports on the object began trickling in on March 17 — St. Patrick's Day — when the Kent Police Department received about a dozen calls about a low-flying object.

The calls poured in again the following week — March 24, 25 and 26 — when more than a hundred calls came into police stations in Carmel, Brewster, Putnam Valley, Yorktown, Mount Kisco and other towns.

Since he invited people who saw the object to call him last week, Imbrogno said he himself has received more than 300 calls.

"Very seldom have I seen such a great mass of reports from a single area," he said. "It's highly unusual."

Most of the people have described a massive, V-shaped object lined with multi-colored lights that flies at tree-top level, Imbrogno said. The object is often reported as about 100 to 150 feet across and made of gray or other dark-colored metal.

Many of the callers have said the object makes a humming noise and that it flies slowly and maneuvers easily, unlike a conventional airplane or helicopter.

Callers come from all walks of life, including doctors, lawyers, police officers, housewives and truck drivers, Imbrogno said. He added that he thinks most are reliable witnesses, though he said a handful were apparently young children or adults who were, "not all there."

One of the people who saw the object, Linda Nicoletti of Tonetta Lake Park in Brewster, said she was sitting in her living room on St. Patrick's Day at about 8:30 p.m. when she saw some red and white lights over the roof of a neighbor's house.

Mrs. Nicoletti, her husband, father-in-law and two of her three children ran outside and found what appeared to be a V-shaped aircraft flying silently at tree-top level.

Mrs. Nicoletti, who said she felt more curiosity than fright, said she

thinks the object may have been some kind of military or experimental aircraft.

"Who knows what they have now?" she said.

Another witness, 17-year-old Jeffrey Salmonese, a Mahopac High School senior, said he took photographs of the object when he and his father spotted it from the yard of their Putnam Valley home on March 24.

Salmonese, who estimated that the large V-shaped object was about 10 miles away over Mahopac, said it was flying toward him lit with red lights when he first saw it at about 8:45 p.m. After abruptly turning south, the object's lights switched to alternating green and white, he said.

One of Salmonese's photographs, published in Gannett-Westchester's Reporter Dispatch newspaper this week, shows an indistinct white light against a gray background.

Researcher Imbrogno said another man, a government official who asked that his name not be made public, said the large craft hovered overhead and projected a beam of light toward the ground.

Several callers who said they saw the object from their automobiles said it interfered with their radio reception as it passed overhead, Imbrogno said.

Police officials interviewed yesterday said they are skeptical of the reports.

Carmel Police Chief Charles Lewis, like several of the police officials, said he believes residents may be seeing a group of small airplanes flying in formation or a hoax designed to resemble a UFO.

Lewis said calls about UFOs are referred to Imbrogno, and that his main concern about the sightings is that the calls may tie up the department's emergency lines.

Trooper S.J. Riley of the Brewster state police barracks said that whenever possible, officers are sent to investigate UFO sightings, but so far have been unable to confirm any of the reports.

Captain Philip Prinz of the Putnam County Sheriff's Department said the department receives reports of UFO sightings, usually a run of several over a short period of time, three or four times a year.

"I don't put much credence in it," he said.

But Imbrogno said he doesn't believe the phenomenon described by the local residents could be airplanes. The research team has checked all nearby airports and can find no records of flights that would resemble the sightings.

He said that the team's report on the sightings will be compiled and sent to the research organization's Illinois headquarters, where it will be entered into a computer data base.